

Nigeria Artificial Intelligence Industry Collective



NIGERIA AI COLLECTIVE COMMUNITY MONTHLY DIGEST

MONTH ENDING MAY 2026

Explore the Latest from Our Community: Key Resources, Insights, and Hot Topics in AI

This Month's Highlights:

Kasi Cloud Launches West Africa's First Hyperscale AI-Ready Data Centre in Lagos

FactCheckAfrica

Unveils AI Civic Tools Ahead of 2027 Elections

CJID Launches AI Advocacy Project to Democratise Access

to AI Skills

Nigeria AI Collective Opens GPU Compute Access for Nigerian Researchers, Startups and AI

Communities

MTN Plans to Turn Its African Tower Network Into a Distributed AI Compute Grid

OpenAI

Rolls Out GPT-5.5 Instant

Anthropic Launches Claude Opus 4.7

Google I/O 2026: Gemini Omni, Anti-

gravity 2.0, Co-Scientist, and Gemini Spark Announced.

Papers

AfriMTEB and AfriE5: Benchmarking and Adapting Text Embedding Models for African Languages

AfroBench - How Good are Large Language Models on African Languages?

BRIGHTER: BRIdging the Gap in Human-Annotated Textual Emotion Recognition Datasets for 28 Languages

Opportunities

LINGUA Africa Open Call for Inclusive AI Language Projects (Masakhane / Microsoft / Gates Foundation / Google.org)

Multilingual Health Question Answering Challenge – Zindi / HASH / ITU (AI4D)

Merck Stimulating Innovative

Research Grant Programme 2026

Niger Delta Digital Summit - Startup Seed Funding 2026

AFD Digital

Energy Challenge 2026 (French Agency for Development)

Upcoming Events

The Bluechip Data and AI Summit 3.0

YPIT AF 2026 - The Artificial Future

AI for Good Global Summit 2026

(ITU / UN)

ICML 2026 - International Conference on Machine Learning

Deep Learning Indaba 2026

Thoughtful Leadership

Kashifu Inuwa Abdullahi

Dr. Bosun Tijani

Kasi Cloud Datacenters Launches Operations, Eyes Nigeria's \$850m Cloud Market



Kasi Cloud Datacenters has officially launched operations with the commissioning of its Lekki campus in Lagos, introducing West Africa's first hyperscale-ready, AI-capable, carrier-neutral data centre platform. Backed by institutional investors, including the Nigeria Sovereign Investment Authority (NSIA), the facility is designed to provide Nigerian enterprises with a world-class local alternative to foreign cloud infrastructure providers.

Nigeria currently spends an estimated \$850 million annually on cloud services hosted abroad, resulting in significant capital outflows and data being stored under foreign jurisdictions. Kasi Cloud aims to reverse this trend by offering secure, scalable, and AI-ready infrastructure within Nigeria, strengthening data sovereignty and supporting the country's digital economy.

Speaking at the launch, CEO Johnson Agogbua described the development as a turning point for Africa's digital future, stating that the continent's data should create value within its own economy. The launch marks an important step in expanding Nigeria's cloud infrastructure capacity and positioning the country as a leading technology hub in West Africa.





FactCheckAfrica launched the Digital Democracy Suite on 7th May 2026 - a set of civic technology tools designed to strengthen public accountability and increase democratic participation ahead of Nigeria's 2027 general elections. The suite was unveiled at Oroki Hub in Osogbo, Osun State, and comprises three interconnected products.

KedereAI is an AI-powered government accountability platform that allows citizens to ask plain-language questions about how public funds are allocated and spent in their communities, using official public records. GovQuest converts the Nigerian Constitution, Electoral Act, and civic concepts into scenario-based games targeted at young Nigerians - making foundational democratic concepts interactive rather than abstract.

The Power Deck is a physical 24-card civic flashcard set for schools and grassroots mobilisation, ensuring civic participation is not limited by internet access or smartphone ownership. The project received support from the Nigeria Youth Futures Fund, Ford Foundation, and MacArthur Foundation.



TV SHOW



AI FOR ALL

SHAPING NIGERIA'S FUTURE

Will AI work for everyone?

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EPISODE 1

Understanding AI & The AI Divide

Live! Thursdays in March, 2026

🕒 1:30 PM

EPISODE 2

Building an Inclusive AI Future



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www.speakoutafricainitiative.org

The AI Advocacy Project is an initiative of the CSOs Community of Practice, organised by the Centre for Journalism Innovation and Development (CJID) within the Nigeria AI Collective. The project is advancing public understanding of artificial intelligence and its impact on jobs, education, governance, and equality, while promoting inclusion of women, youth, rural communities, and persons with disabilities in AI conversations.

It also simplifies complex AI issues into accessible formats and strengthens the capacity of civil society and media actors to engage in responsible and fair AI use in Nigeria.

Public engagement activities under the project span broadcast, digital, and interactive platforms:
TV Spotlight

The AI for CSO Community of Practice Group hosted television conversations on Independent Television and Radio of Nigeria (ITV) titled “AI For All: Shaping Nigeria’s Future.” The episodes (2) focused on making artificial intelligence more understandable, inclusive, and relevant to everyday realities in Nigeria.

At its core, the discussions unpacked two major themes:

- Understanding AI and the AI Divide
- Building an Inclusive AI Future

The initiative was implemented by members of the CSOs Community of Practice, put together by the [Centre for Journalism Innovation and Development \(CJID\)](#) under the [Nigeria AI Collective](#): [Dataphyte Foundation](#), [TrustedTech Initiative](#), [TechHerNG](#), [Cedar Foundation for Disability](#), [NEST Africa AI Innovation Lab](#), [Speak Out Africa Initiative \(SOAI\)](#), and [Voice of Women Empowerment Foundation](#)



Nigeria AI Collective Opens GPU Compute Access for Nigerian Researchers, Startups, and AI Communities

For most AI builders in Nigeria, the bottleneck has never been talent or ideas. It has been compute. The cost of GPU access, model training infrastructure, and the technical support needed to move a project from prototype to deployment has quietly been one of the most consistent barriers separating promising work from actual impact. AI Collective is moving to close that gap.

AI Collective has launched an open GPU Compute Access Program targeting three groups that have consistently carried that burden: researchers, startups, and community builders across Nigeria and Africa.

The program is not just a compute grant. Selected beneficiaries gain access to model training support, AI infrastructure guidance, fine-tuning assistance, and mentorship, structured around what a project actually needs to move forward, not just raw hours on a machine. Accepted participants will also have the opportunity to showcase their work at the AI Summit in October 2026. The program is structured around three clear entry points.

Researchers and academic teams, including postgraduate students, NLP researchers, language AI labs, and independent investigators, can apply for compute access to accelerate experimentation, model development, and publication. The focus is on work that

pushes the frontier of what Nigerian AI research can produce and contribute to the global conversation.

Startups and product teams building AI-powered solutions can apply for infrastructure support to move faster without being held back by cost. From MVP completion to pilot deployment, the program is designed to meet founders at whatever stage they are at and help them get to the next one.

AI communities, developer groups, open-source collectives, language AI initiatives, and innovation networks can apply for resources to power collaborative projects, training programmes, and ecosystem-building work at scale. The conviction behind this track is straightforward, a well-resourced community compounds. Every builder it trains and every project it enables multiplies the return on the investment.

Applicants are expected to commit to responsible and ethical use of data, acknowledge Nigeria AI Collective as a contributor in any outputs the support makes possible, and where applicable, publish findings as a white paper that contributes back to the broader knowledge commons.

This is compute access oriented toward builders who are serious about impact.

Apply here: <https://bit.ly/AIComputeSupport>



Your Research Deserves More Compute Power.

Access GPU resources through the Nigeria AI Collective's compute support initiative for researchers building impactful AI solutions and advancing scientific innovation.

Selected applicants will also have the opportunity to showcase their work in person at the AI Summit in **October 2026.**

WHO CAN APPLY?

- Researchers
- Academic Institutions
- AI Research Labs
- Language Technology Researchers
- Innovation Fellows

Apply Here: <https://bit.ly/AIComputeSupport>



Building AI Products? Get the Compute You Need.

The Nigeria AI Collective is helping startups overcome compute limitations by providing access to GPU resources for AI development, testing, and deployment.

Participants may also be featured to showcase their solutions in person at the AI Summit **October 2026.**

WHO CAN APPLY?

- AI Startups
- Product Teams
- Technical Founders
- Machine Learning Teams
- Innovation Hubs

Apply Here: <https://bit.ly/AIComputeSupport>





Access Free GPU to Advance Your AI Research

The Nigeria AI Collective is supporting researchers and academic teams with strategic GPU compute access to accelerate AI research, experimentation, model training, and innovation

Selected participants should be willing to showcase their work in person at the AI Summit in

October 2026.

WHO CAN APPLY?

- AI Researchers
- Academic Labs
- Research Teams
- Postgraduate Students
- Language & NLP Researchers

Apply Here: Registration Form



MTN Plans to Turn Its African Tower Network Into a Distributed AI Compute Grid



MTN Group plans to convert its African tower estate into a distributed AI compute fabric, installing open GPU infrastructure at base-station sites so that the same hardware can run both the cellular network and edge AI inference workloads. The plan was set out by MTN Group Chief Technology and Information Officer Charles Molapisi, described as MTN's most detailed explanation yet of how it intends to position itself as the infrastructure layer of Africa's AI economy.

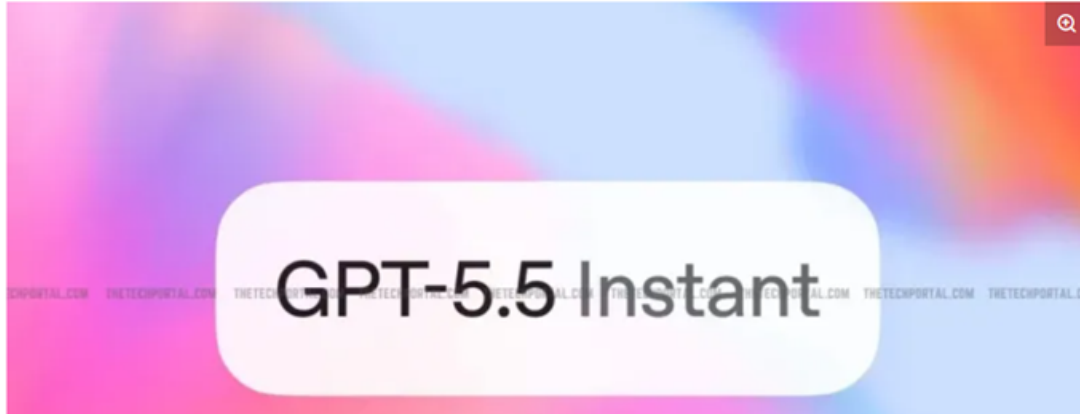
Every cellular tower today has a baseband unit at its base, single-purpose hardware that exists only to drive the radio access network. Molapisi said MTN will replace these with open GPU configurations capable of running the radio plus AI inference, in what the company has described as a "distributed AI grid." The ambition, he said, is for MTN to become "the biggest distributor of edge inference in the continent."

The group also confirmed it will build two new AI-enabled data centres, one in South Africa and one in Nigeria, as part of a broader AI strategy spanning silicon procurement, cloud platforms, model curation, and co-developed applications with partners. The strategic case rests on Molapisi's argument that Africa risks repeating its commodity history in the AI era. With about 1% of global computing power on the continent today, Africa stands to export raw data the way it has long exported raw minerals, only to import the intelligence built from it at a premium.

For Nigeria specifically, the confirmation of a new AI-enabled data centre in-country, combined with MTN Nigeria's tower footprint across the country, means that the physical infrastructure for distributed AI computation at the edge is no longer a distant ambition. It is a named, funded, and actively planned investment. The data sovereignty conversation this community has been having is about to have a very concrete physical expression.

A.I., News

OpenAI rolls out 'GPT-5.5 Instant' as ChatGPT's new default, improving accuracy and speed



TOP STORIES

Tata inks mega deal with Netherlands' ASML for its \$11Bn chip manufacturing project

May 17, 2026

Delhivery Q4 FY26 revenue rises 30% to ₹2850 crore, profit remains flat at ₹73.4 crore

OpenAI has rolled out GPT-5.5 Instant as ChatGPT's new default model, delivering more accurate, personalised, and context-aware responses. The update reduces hallucinated claims by more than 50% in some high-stakes scenarios and introduces 'memory sources' controls that show users which contextual information shaped responses. Simultaneously, the US government is pushing for access to AI models before public release - with Microsoft and xAI among companies reported to have agreed to provide regulators with early model access, marking a turning point in how frontier AI systems are overseen globally.

Anthropic Launches Claude Opus 4.7



Anthropic launched Claude Opus 4.7 On 16th April 2026, a more advanced version of its Claude AI model with stronger reasoning, coding, and complex task capabilities. The release positioned Claude Opus 4.7 among the leading frontier AI systems globally.

For Nigerian developers and digital professionals, more powerful AI coding tools could improve software development speed, research productivity, and business automation. The growing availability of advanced AI assistants may also support Nigeria's expanding startup ecosystem and remote tech workforce.



At its I/O 2026 developer keynote, Google announced Antigravity 2.0, a standalone desktop application built entirely around agent orchestration, alongside a new Antigravity CLI, an Antigravity SDK, Managed Agents in the Gemini API, and enterprise support through the Gemini Enterprise Agent Platform. During the keynote, Google demonstrated the platform's capability live on stage: Antigravity 2.0's parallel agent system built the core framework of a working operating system in approximately 12 hours, launching 93 separate sub-agents during the task, processing billions of tokens, and completing the project for under \$1,000 in computing costs. Google then ran the classic game Doom on the AI-created OS.

With the new desktop app, users can orchestrate multiple agents and execute tasks simultaneously, design custom subagent workflows, and schedule tasks that run automatically in the background. The platform integrates natively with Google AI Studio, Android, and Firebase, and adds native voice command support. Google is also introducing a new AI Ultra plan priced at \$100 per month, offering 5x higher AI limits than the Pro plan. Notably, Google has set a June 18, 2026 shutdown date for the existing Gemini CLI, teams with production pipelines currently built on Gemini CLI have 28 days to migrate.

For Nigeria's growing developer and AI builder community, Antigravity 2.0 is directly relevant. Google is moving its developer tooling away from IDE-centric assistance and toward multi-agent workflow management as the primary abstraction, which means Nigerian developers building AI-powered products now have access to an enterprise-grade agent orchestration platform that can compress weeks of development work into hours, at a cost accessible to startups.



Google Introduces Gemini Spark: A 24/7 Personal AI Agent



The third major Google I/O 2026 announcement is Gemini Spark - a 24/7 personal AI agent designed to help users navigate their digital life by taking action on their behalf and under their direction.

Spark runs on Gemini 3.5 and is built on Google Antigravity, enabling it to perform long-running tasks in the background without requiring the user to keep their device open. Because it runs on dedicated virtual machines on Google Cloud, it operates independently and continuously. Spark will integrate seamlessly across Google tools and, soon, with third-party platforms through MCP (Model Context Protocol).

For Nigeria's AI community, Gemini Spark signals a broader industry shift: AI is moving from a tool you interact with to an agent that works for you between interactions. This has direct implications for productivity, business operations, and the design of AI products built for Nigerian users - where ambient, background intelligence may prove more practically useful than on-demand querying.

Home-grown Research with Global Recognition

Papers: [AfriMTEB and AfriE5: Benchmarking and Adapting Text Embedding Models for African Languages](#)

Authors: Kosei Uemura, Miaoran Zhang, David Ifeoluwa Adelani

Venue: EACL 2026 (19th Conference of the European Chapter of the Association for Computational Linguistics, Rabat, Morocco) - Main Conference, Long Papers

Text embedding models are what allow AI systems to search for relevant documents, answer questions from a knowledge base, and avoid hallucinating by grounding responses in real data. The standard way to measure how well these models work is through benchmarks, and the dominant one, MMTEB, barely covers African languages, with the few tasks it does include repurposed from translation datasets rather than reflecting actual African-language use cases.

AfriMTEB addresses this directly by introducing a regional expansion of MMTEB covering 59 languages, 14 tasks, and 38 datasets, with six newly added datasets spanning 14 to 56 African languages, and introducing entirely new tasks such as hate speech detection, intent detection, and emotion classification, all highly relevant to Nigeria's digital landscape. Hausa, Yoruba, and Igbo are explicitly included. Alongside the benchmark, the authors introduce AfriE5, a purpose-built African-language embedding model.

AfriE5 achieves the strongest overall macro-average among open-weight embedding models on AfriMTEB, with statistically significant gains across several task families, and is competitive with proprietary models such as Gemini Embedding-001. Notably, it achieves this while being significantly smaller than most competing models, a critical advantage in compute-constrained environments.

For Nigeria's AI developers, AfriMTEB offers something immediately practical: a rigorous, standardised way to test whether the systems you are building for search, chatbots, or content moderation actually work in Nigerian languages, not just in English. AfriE5 provides the model to start building them.

Stepping back, the paper makes a clear and timely argument: building effective speech technologies for Africa is not just a modeling problem, it is a data problem shaped by culture, diversity, and ethics. By releasing African Voices as an open, well-documented resource grounded in real-world language use, the authors provide both a foundation for robust ASR research and a call to action for the community to invest in more inclusive, representative speech data. In doing so, the work moves the conversation forward, from simply including African languages in AI systems to building them on data that truly reflects how Africans speak.

Home-grown Research with Global Recognition

Papers: [AfroBench - How Good are Large Language Models on African Languages?](#)

Authors: Jessica Ojo, Odunayo Ogundepo, Akintunde Oladipo, Kelechi Ogueji, Jimmy Lin, Pontus Stenetorp, David Ifeoluwa Adelani

Venue: Findings of the Association for Computational Linguistics (ACL 2025), Vienna, Austria

When technology companies and researchers assess how well their AI systems perform, they typically rely on benchmarks - standardised sets of tests that measure a model's ability to translate text, answer questions, classify content, and reason through problems. The challenge for African languages is that most of these benchmarks were built for English and a small number of European languages, meaning the performance of AI systems on languages spoken by hundreds of millions of Africans is largely unmeasured - and therefore largely unimproved.

This paper introduces AfroBench, a comprehensive benchmark for evaluating AI language models across 64 indigenous African languages, covering 15 distinct tasks and 22 datasets. The tasks range from sentiment analysis and machine translation to mathematical reasoning and question answering - giving researchers and developers a structured way to test whether the AI models they build or deploy actually work for African-language speakers.

The findings are direct: large performance gaps persist between English and African languages across almost every task. Even state-of-the-art proprietary models like GPT-4o significantly underperform on African languages compared to their English capability. However, the paper also shows that when sufficient training data in a given language exists, performance improves substantially - confirming that the gap is a data problem as much as a model problem. The benchmark covers key Nigerian languages including Yoruba, Hausa, and Igbo, making it directly relevant to researchers and developers building AI products for Nigerian users. AfroBench is openly available, providing Nigeria's growing AI research community with a practical tool to measure and close this gap.

Papers: [BRIGHTER: BRIdging the Gap in Human-Annotated Textual Emotion Recognition Datasets for 28 Languages](#)

Authors: Shamsuddeen Hassan Muhammad, Nedjma Ousidhoum, Idris Abdulmumin, Jan Philip Wahle, Terry Ruas, Meriem Beloucif, Christine de Kock, Nirmal Surange, Daniela Teodorescu, Ibrahim Said Ahmad, David Ifeoluwa Adelani, Alham Fikri Aji, Felermimo D. M. A. Ali, Chiamaka Ijeoma Chukwuneke, Murja Sani Gadanya, Falalu Ibrahim Lawan, and 27 additional co-authors.

Venue: ACL 2025 (Annual Meeting of the Association for Computational Linguistics) Best Resource Paper Award

Every time you interact with a chatbot that detects frustration in your message, or a mental health app that reads emotional tone, there is an AI system doing emotion recognition underneath. The problem is that almost all the data used to build and test those systems comes from English. For the hundreds of millions of people whose languages are not in that data, these systems either fail silently or are never built at all.

BRIGHTER directly addresses that gap. The paper presents BRIGHTER, a collection of multi-labeled emotion-annotated datasets in 28 languages, covering predominantly low-resource languages from Africa, Asia,

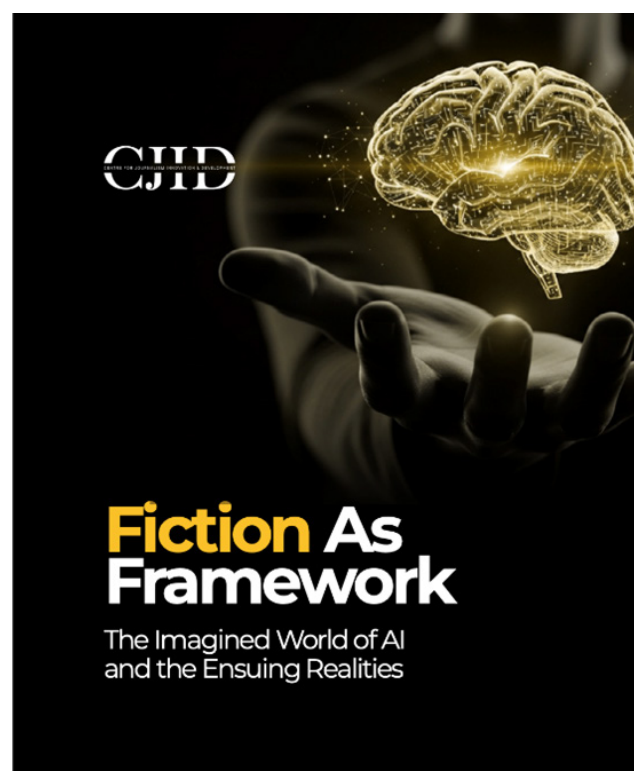
Home-grown Research with Global Recognition

Eastern Europe, and Latin America, with instances from various domains annotated by fluent speakers. Each entry carries multiple simultaneous emotion labels with intensity scores, capturing the reality that a single text can express anger and fear at once, a feature most existing datasets fail to handle. The dataset spans social media, news, and conversational text, making it far more representative of how language actually lives in the real world.

The Nigerian contribution is substantial. Chiamaka Ijeoma Chukwuneke contributed to dataset design, while Murja Sani Gadanya and Falalu Ibrahim Lawan led annotation for Hausa, a reminder that building African-language datasets is a community act, requiring speakers who understand how emotions are expressed culturally, not just linguistically. David Ifeoluwa Adelani is one of the central architects of the broader research programme this paper belongs to.

The team tested five leading LLMs, including LLaMA-3.3-70B and DeepSeek-R1-70B, on the dataset in both monolingual and cross-lingual settings. Results were instructive: even the most capable models underperform significantly on low-resource African languages compared to English, and cross-lingual transfer degrades meaningfully as language distance from English increases. For Hausa, Yoruba, and Igbo, the gap is especially pronounced.

The practical implications go beyond academia. Emotion recognition is increasingly embedded in content moderation, mental health platforms, and political discourse analysis, all sectors growing rapidly in Nigeria. Without datasets like BRIGHTER, those systems will keep being built on English-derived assumptions, producing tools that are inaccurate and potentially harmful when deployed in African contexts. That this paper won the Best Resource Paper Award at ACL 2025, the most prestigious annual NLP conference in the world is recognition of just how consequential a contribution it represents.



Knowledge Resource

Author: Oluwapelumi Oginni

This CJID publication “Fiction As Framework: The Imagined World of AI and the Ensuing Realities”, examines how AI is moving from science fiction into everyday life, bringing both opportunities and challenges. Drawing on classic literary and cinematic visions of AI, it explores issues such as bias, surveillance, inequality, and the gradual undermining of human judgment, while highlighting the need for ethical design, accountability, and inclusive governance.

Read the [full report](#) to see how lessons from fiction can guide the responsible development and use of AI today.

Opportunities and Events

An overview of upcoming events, available funding, proposal invitations, and other timely opportunities shared within the Community.

LINGUA Africa Open Call for Inclusive AI Language Projects



LINGUA Africa Open Call

Empowering inclusive AI through open language resources

Deadline – 15th June 2026

[LINGUA Africa Open Call for Inclusive AI Language Projects \(Masakhane / Microsoft / Gates Foundation / Google.org\)](#)

The Masakhane African Languages Hub, in collaboration with the Microsoft AI for Good Lab, the Bill & Melinda Gates Foundation, and Google.org, has launched LINGUA Africa, an open call for proposals to build the linguistic foundations necessary for truly inclusive AI in Africa. The initiative invites nonprofits, universities, research institutes, social enterprises, cultural organisations, startups, and consortia to submit proposals.

Selected projects will gain access to direct funding ranging from \$50,000 to \$250,000, as well as Azure and Google Cloud Platform (GCP) credits worth up to \$400,000 for high-impact projects, alongside expert mentorship and technical collaboration.

The initiative prioritises projects that connect open language resources to real-world use cases and community outcomes, with an aim to ensure that African languages are not treated as an afterthought in the AI era, but as essential parts of a more inclusive digital future. Relevant focus areas include agriculture, education, healthcare, and civic services, across text, speech, and vision modalities.

Opportunities and Events

LINGUA Africa Open Call for Inclusive AI Language Projects



30 Apr - 22 Jun, 2026 | Open Now | Online

Multilingual Health Question Answering in African Languages

\$5,000 USD to be won — Build AI for Africa's health communities

Join this Zindi Challenge and build a model that accurately answers health questions in low-resource African languages like Luganda, Kiswahili, Akan and Amharic. Help bridge the gap in maternal, sexual and reproductive health information across Sub-Saharan Africa.

Register here: <https://bit.ly/4u5VrFG>

Scan this code to register for this challenge

ZINDI

Logos: Artificial Intelligence for Development, IDRC-CRDI, Canada, UK International Development, SURE AI, HIRSH, Mak-AI, WFP, Academy for Health Innovation Uganda, ZINDI, ITU

Deadline - 21st June 2026

[Multilingual Health Question Answering Challenge — Zindi / HASH / ITU \(AI4D\)](#)

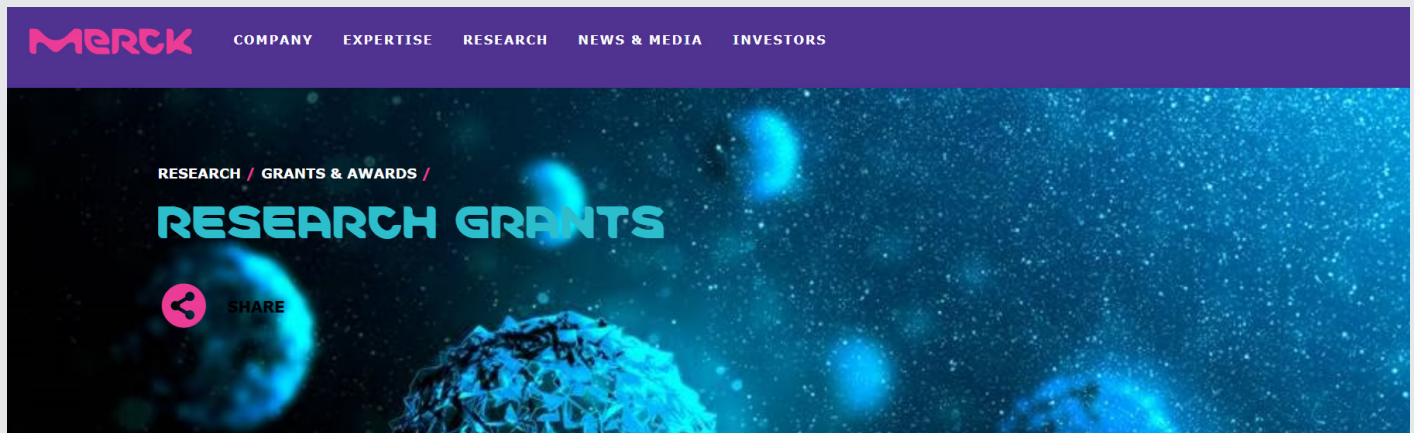
Zindi, in partnership with the International Telecommunication Union and the Hub for Artificial Intelligence in Maternal, Sexual and Reproductive Health (HASH), has launched a multilingual AI challenge with a total prize pool of \$5,000 USD. The competition invites data scientists, AI researchers, machine learning engineers, and natural language processing specialists to develop multilingual health-focused AI models capable of supporting underserved African communities.

This challenge calls on participants to build multilingual AI models capable of answering health-related questions accurately and fluently in

low-resource African languages using curated health question-and-answer datasets. Strong solutions could support health worker assistants, patient education tools, and clinic support systems in underserved communities. Prizes include \$2,500 USD for 1st place, \$1,500 USD for 2nd, and \$1,000 USD for 3rd.

The competition is open globally and allows individual or team participation. Nigerian AI researchers, developers, and NLP enthusiasts are eligible to apply.

Merck Stimulating Innovative Research Grant Programme 2026



MERCK COMPANY EXPERTISE RESEARCH NEWS & MEDIA INVESTORS

RESEARCH / GRANTS & AWARDS /

RESEARCH GRANTS

SHARE

Deadline - August 31st, 2026

[Merck Stimulating Innovative Research Grant Programme 2026](#)

Opportunities and Events

The Merck Stimulating Innovative Research Grant Programme offers grants across multiple priority areas, including one focused specifically on artificial intelligence in cell culture media and process development — worth up to €150,000 per year for up to three years. Other grants under the programme reach up to €250,000 per year for up to two years. Submissions are accepted until 31 August 2026.

The programme is open to researchers, scientists, and research institutions worldwide across multiple scientific and technological fields, and successful projects may be funded for up to three years. Nigerian researchers at universities, research institutes, and industry working in AI, biotechnology, and related fields are eligible to apply. The multi-stage process involves an open application followed by a collaborative deep-dive workshop with Merck scientists.

Niger Delta Digital Summit - Startup Seed Funding 2026



Deadline – 16th June 2026

[Niger Delta Digital Summit - Startup Seed Funding 2026](#)

As part of the 2026 Niger Delta Digital Summit, a total of ₦1,800,000 in seed funding is being awarded to the top three promising startups or digital innovators in the Niger Delta region, with 1st Prize at ₦1,000,000, 2nd Prize at ₦500,000, and 3rd Prize at ₦300,000.

Startups working in sectors such as fintech, agritech, health-tech, edtech, e-commerce, or green-tech are

encouraged to apply, especially if they are based in one of the nine Niger Delta states (Abia, Akwa Ibom, Bayelsa, Cross River, Delta, Edo, Imo, Ondo, Rivers). To qualify, the startup should be between six months and five years old, and should show clear innovation or potential impact in its sector.

In addition to funding, winners gain access to complimentary workspace, cloud storage support, and masterclass training, as well as a featured spotlight at the summit and access to business mentorship and increased visibility.

Opportunities and Events

AFD Digital Energy Challenge 2026 (French Agency for Development)



DIGITAL ENERGY CHALLENGE 2026 CALL FOR PROJECTS

Powering Africa's energy future
through digital innovation.



Funding up to
€400,000



Deadline
17 JUNE 2026



For Startups
& SMEs



Innovate. Scale. Impact Africa.
Be part of the change.

Deadline – 17th June 2026

[AFD Digital Energy Challenge 2026 \(French Agency for Development\)](#)

Startups, SMEs, and technology innovators developing digital solutions for Africa's energy sector can apply for the Digital Energy Challenge 2026. The programme supports projects improving energy access, renewable energy integration, grid performance, and energy efficiency through digital innovation. Funding is available through two tracks: a Tech Accelerator offering up to €150,000 per project, and a Partnership Challenge providing up to €400,000 for collaborative initiatives.

Beyond funding, selected applicants receive technical support, strategic guidance, ecosystem visibility, and opportunities to strengthen and scale their solutions across African markets. Eligible projects should demonstrate innovation, progress beyond the idea stage, and potential for measurable impact.

The opportunity is particularly relevant for startups building solutions in smart energy systems, renewable energy technologies, digital infrastructure, data systems, and utility performance improvement.

Upcoming Events

An overview of upcoming events, available funding, proposal invitations, and other timely opportunities shared within the Community.

1. The Bluechip Data and AI Summit 3.0

Date: 10 June, 2026

Location: Lagos, Nigeria

This event brings together industry leaders, innovators, and policymakers to explore practical AI and data-driven solutions transforming key sectors across the continent. The Summit focuses on how artificial intelligence and data can be applied to real-world challenges in finance, healthcare, governance, and other critical areas, positioning itself as a key platform for advancing Africa's digital transformation.



2. YPIT AF 2026 - The Artificial Future

Date: Hackathon: 30th May - 6th June 2026 | Conference: 13th June 2026

Location: Lagos, Nigeria (Hybrid - Hackathon in-person + online workshops) | Conference: The Civic Centre, Lagos.

As Africa's digital landscape continues to expand, so do the challenges and opportunities in cybersecurity. The Africa CISO Summit in Nigeria is a unique gathering that convenes over 200 of the continent's foremost cybersecurity leaders, decision-makers, and innovators. This May, we'll host an exclusive summit designed to address the pressing challenges faced by the region while highlighting the opportunities presented by emerging technologies and investment trends.

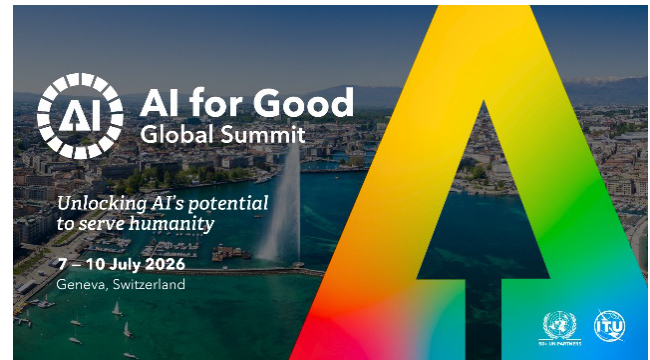
Upcoming Events

3. AI for Good Global Summit 2026 (ITU / UN)

Date: 7th - 10th July 2026

Location: Palexpo Convention Centre, Geneva, Switzerland (In-person + Remote Streaming)

The AI for Good Global Summit returns to Geneva for its seventh edition, organised by the International Telecommunication Union (ITU) alongside dozens of UN agencies and supported by the Government of Switzerland. Across three stages, the Summit features keynotes, expert discussions, workshops, and live demonstrations exploring how AI is shaping the future of work, advancing healthcare, transforming creativity and culture, supporting education and skills development, and opening new perspectives on longevity. Open to all visitors, the Summit brings together policymakers, industry leaders, researchers, innovators, artists, and youth from around the world. Participants can choose to attend either physically in



Geneva or watch sessions on the Centre Stage remotely. The inaugural Global Dialogue on AI Governance, established under a UN General Assembly Resolution, will be held back-to-back with the Summit.

The 2026 edition introduces a paid registration model for in-person attendance. Nigerian attendees requiring visa support letters should note the 9 June 2026 deadline for ITU member approval.



are available, covering registration and hotel for in-person attendance, or a virtual pass for remote participants — those who register before the deadline and are awarded aid will be refunded. Accepted papers and talk recordings are made publicly available after the event for those unable to travel.

4. ICML 2026 - International Conference on Machine Learning

Date: 6th - 11th July 2026

Location: Seoul, South Korea (In-person)

The 43rd edition of the International Conference on Machine Learning remains one of the world's most prestigious AI research venues. Globally renowned for presenting cutting-edge research across machine learning, AI, statistics, data science, machine vision, computational biology, speech recognition, and robotics, it is a key reference point for anyone serious about the direction of the field. This year, 6,352 papers were accepted from 23,918 submissions, a 26.6% acceptance rate. The programme runs July 6 (Expo & Tutorials), July 7-9 (Main Conference), and July 10-11 (Workshops).

Nigerian researchers with accepted papers and community members wishing to attend as delegates can register at the official website. Financial aid grants

Upcoming Events

5. Deep Learning Indaba 2026

Date: 7th - 10th July 2026

Location: Pan-Atlantic University (PAU), Lagos, Nigeria

The 2026 edition of the Deep Learning Indaba takes place 2nd–7th August in Lagos, Nigeria, centred on the theme of Sovereign Intelligence: Africa's capacity to develop and direct its own AI systems, data, and scientific future. The programme will feature keynotes, tutorials, workshops, practical sessions, research presentations, and community discussions, all designed to showcase the depth and diversity of African machine learning and to strengthen the AI community. Applications to participate are now open.

This is Africa's premier annual AI gathering and will be hosted in Nigeria for the first time. A landmark moment for the Nigeria AI ecosystem.



Thought Leadership



Kashifu Inuwa Abdullahi

(Director General, National Information Technology Development Agency - NITDA)

At an international audience of policymakers, technologists, and investors, 2026.

"AI is shifting the skills we value today, as well as the processes we use to do our daily work. To drive strategic leadership, you need to be an AI-driven leader and find a way to use AI as a tool to create co-intelligence - whereby you bring people and computers to work together to deliver your strategic vision. Strategy must always come first, and technology second."

Read more: nitda.gov.ng



Dr. Bosun Tijani

(Minister of Communications, Innovation & Digital Economy, Nigeria)

At the BBC/UN Town Hall on Africa and Artificial Intelligence, UN General Assembly, New York:

"The stronger your digital economy gets, the more cyber-attacks you are going to experience as a country. Growth and vulnerability now move together in the digital age. Building a resilient digital economy requires coordinated action, trusted collaboration, and a cybersecurity framework that brings government, industry, and citizens together to protect our shared digital future."

Read more: un.org/osaa

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